



Limestone

△ **Pterodactylus fossil**, beautifully preserved in limestone

imestone is largely made up of calcium carbonate and, depending on its formation, can be clastic, crystalline, granular, or massive. A sedimentary rock, most limestone forms in calm marine waters, occurring when marine organisms die and fragments of shell, skeletal debris, and coral break down into sediment. Minerals then cement the sediment together, turning it into limestone. It was used in many ancient carvings, and is regularly employed as a construction material, a base for roads, a white pigment or a filler in paints, plastics, and toothpaste.

Specification

Rock type Marine, chemical, sedimentary | **Fossils** Marine and freshwater invertebrates | **Major minerals** Calcite
Minor minerals Aragonite, dolomite, siderite, quartz, pyrite
Colours White, grey, pink | **Texture** Fine to medium, angular to rounded | **Locations** Worldwide



Limestone statue | **Carved** | Finely detailed mortuary statues, such as this one from 2nd-century CE Palmyra, were carved throughout the Roman world. This high-relief bust of a woman is richly carved with necklaces, bracelets, brooches, and rings.

Veil with scallop detailing

Surface contains fossils



Fossiliferous rock | **Rough** | Limestone-bearing fossils such as this specimen containing bryozoans is often sawn and polished, and used as cladding for buildings.



Freshwater limestone | **Rough** | Limestone is generally formed in salt water, but it can also form in fresh water, as with this fossiliferous example.

Sphinx and base carved from one complete piece



Sphinx | **Carved** | Just like the Great Sphinx in Giza, this smaller version is also carved from limestone – a favourite carving medium in antiquity, when this sphinx was made.



Homeosaurus fossil | **Cut** | Fine-grained limestone provides the perfect environment for fossil preservation, as shown with this Jurassic Homeosaurus.